

Be very cautious of using unfamiliar commands when logged in as root. But go ahead and have your fun trying out new things when logged in as a user.

If you know the consequences of a command that needs root privileges, just use the “**su -**” command to temporarily log in as root. When you type in “**su -**” and press *[Enter]*, you will be prompted for the root password. Entering your root password will allow you to execute the command. Avoid starting your session as root, though.

You can easily distinguish if you are operating as a user or root. A user prompt will contain the \$ sign, while the root will have the # sign in the prompt.

Remember that all UNIX commands will work on all distributions of Linux. There are, however, certain commands created by particular distributors which will work only on their distribution. So, keep your user manual ready if you have one.

If at any point you need to know what a command does, all you need to do is type in “**man <command>**” and press *[Enter]*. Sorry ladies, this does not command your man to do the dishes—it is short for “**Manual**”! Doing this gives you an explanation of the command specified after “**man**”. For example, typing in “**man fdisk**” will display the manual information for the fdisk command.

Most commands contain options that you can use by placing a dash (-) followed by the appropriate letter. Combinations of these options can also be used. One only needs to remember what letter does what. You might find it difficult initially, but as they say, practice makes you perfect!

In the prompt, you can press the up and down arrow keys to get to previously typed commands instead of typing them again.